

Hills Like White Elephants Inference Guide

To **infer** means to gather clues in a text to understand what is happening. Think of it as **reading between the lines**. Today we will do just that.

Directions: Read each passage. List any clues that may help you understand the inference into the chart below

'It's really an awfully simple operation, Jig,' the man said. 'It's not really an operation at all.'

The girl looked at the ground the table legs rested on.

'I know you wouldn't mind it, Jig. It's really not anything. It's just to let the air in.'

The girl did not say anything.

'I'll go with you and I'll stay with you all the time. They just let the air in and then it's all perfectly natural.'

'That's the only thing that bothers us. It's the only thing that's made us unhappy.'

The girl looked at the bead curtain, put her hand out and took hold of two of the strings of beads.

'I know we will. You don't have to be afraid. I've known lots of people that have done it.'

'So have I,' said the girl. 'And afterwards they were all so happy.'

'Well,' the man said, 'if you don't want to you don't have to. I wouldn't have you do it if you didn't want to. But I know it's perfectly simple.'

'And you really want to?'

'I think it's the best thing to do. But I don't want you to do it if you don't really want to.'

'And if I do it you'll be happy and things will be like they were and you'll love me?'

'I love you now. You know I love you.'

'I know. But if I do it, then it will be nice again if I say things are like white elephants, and you'll like it?'

'I'll love it. I love it now but I just can't think about it. You know how I get when I worry.'

'If I do it you won't ever worry?'

'I won't worry about that because it's perfectly simple.'

'Then I'll do it. Because I don't care about me.'

'And we could have all this,' she said. 'And we could have everything and every day we make it more impossible.'

'What did you say?'

'I said we could have everything.'

'We can have everything.'

'No, we can't.'

'We can have the whole world.'

'No, we can't.'

'We can go everywhere.'

'No, we can't. It isn't ours any more.'

'It's ours.'

'No, it isn't. And once they take it away, you never get it back.'

'But they haven't taken it away.'

'You've got to realize,' he said, 'that I don't want you to do it if you don't want to. I'm perfectly willing to go through with it if it means anything to you.'

'Doesn't it mean anything to you? We could get along.'

'Of course it does. But I don't want anybody but you. I don't want anyone else. And I know it's perfectly simple.'

'Yes, you know it's perfectly simple.'

'It's all right for you to say that, but I do know it.'

'Would you do something for me now?'

'I'd do anything for you.'

'Would you please please please please please please stop talking?'

Evidence said by the Man	Evidence said by the Woman
"It's really a simple operation"	"The girl looked at the ground"
"I know we will. You don't have to be afraid. I've known lots of people that have done it."	"That's the only thing that bothers us. It's the only thing that's made us unhappy."
"And we could have everything and every day we make it more impossible."	'No, we can't.'
'It's ours.'	'No, it isn't. And once they take it away, you never get it back.'
'Doesn't it mean anything to you? We could get along.'	'Of course it does. But I don't want anybody but you. I don't want anyone else. And I know it's perfectly simple.'
'But they haven't taken it away.'	The girl did not say anything.
'Well,' the man said, 'if you don't want to you don't have to. I wouldn't have you do it if you didn't want to. But I know it's perfectly simple.'	The girl looked at the bead curtain, put her hand out and took hold of two of the strings of beads.
'You've got to realize,' he said, 'that I don't want you to do it if you don't want to. I'm perfectly willing to go through with it if it means anything to you.'	'Would you do something for me now?'
'Then I'll do it. Because I don't care about me.'	'I know. But if I do it, then it will be nice again if I say things are like white elephants, and you'll like it?'
'I think it's the best thing to do. But I don't want you to do it if you don't really want to.'	'And if I do it you'll be happy and things will be like they were and you'll love me?'
'I'd do anything for you.'	'Would you please please please please please please please stop talking?'
'I'll love it. I love it now but I just can't think about it. You know how I get when I worry.'	The girl looked at the ground the table legs rested on.
'I'll go with you and I'll stay with you all the	'Yes, you know it's perfectly simple.'

time. They just let the air in and then it's all perfectly natural.'	
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Final Inference

Directions: Answer the questions using the completed chart above with evidence from the text for the three questions.

1. What is the topic of conversation?

Eloping is the topic of the conversation with the white elephant being the both of them being a blessing and a burden to each other without any assistance from any other family and having a non official wed. Like the simple operation comment and the girl saying that the only thing that bothers us.

2. What do the man and woman want?

The man and the woman want to be together but due to their running away they will struggle together due to this.

3. In your opinion, what decision was made? Why? (1 paragraph)

The decision to be made is to be yet undecided, in my opinion both know the struggle that will come and have an aversion to commitment. With both seeing things very differently the woman sees it as a burden with each other being a blessing yet a burden to each other. The man simply doesn't see it at all and just sees a mountain unable to see her explanation. Love can't be everything in the eye of the woman. While the man think the love can be what make each other happy.